

FIGHTER AND STRIKE AIRCRAFT

Fighter aircraft have been transformed since the first subsonic jets fought each other in the Korean War (1950–53). Today, they have the capacity to travel at over twice the speed of sound, and are also capable of carrying an enormous weight of missiles, rockets, and bombs – well in excess of the bomb loads carried by World War II heavy bombers such as the B17 (see pp.314–17). The most recent advances, however, have been made in the field of aviation electronics. The latest fly-by-wire (i.e. computerized) control systems allow a manoeuvrability that would be impossible using conventional mechanical or human means, while weapons can be guided towards their target with pinpoint accuracy.



Armed with two 23mm cannons (left fuselage), plus a single 37mm cannon (right fuselage), and up to 1,000kg (2,200lb) of bombs/rockets

Polish aviation insignia

▲ MIKOYAN-GUREVICH MIG-15

Date 1949 **Origin** Soviet Union

Wingspan 10.08m (33ft)

Length 10m (33ft)

Top speed 1,100kph (684mph)

Engine 26.5kN (5,950lb) Klimov VK-1 turbojet

The Soviet Union broke new ground with this advanced fighter that saw the first ever jet combat with the US F-86 over Korea. The MiG-15 was also manufactured in China, Czechoslovakia, and Poland.



Armed with 20mm M61 Gatling Cannon, plus guided missiles and up to 7,700kg (17,000lb) ordnance

Ventral fin (port)

▲ GENERAL DYNAMICS F-16C FIGHTING FALCON

Date 1978 **Origin** US

Wingspan 9.96m (32½ft)

Length 15.06m (49½ft)

Top speed 2,410kph (1,500mph)

Engine 76.3kN (17,155lb) F110-GE-100 turbofan

The multirole F-16 was built in response to the US Air Force's demand for a lightweight fighter. One of the first aircraft to use fly-by-wire controls, it was fast and extremely manoeuvrable.



Armed with two 30mm Aden cannon in underwing pods, plus missiles and up to 3,650kg (8,000lb) other ordnance

Fuel drop tank



Armed with six .5in machine-guns, plus up to 2,400kg (5,300lb) of bombs/rockets

Bubble canopy

Fuel drop tank

▲ NORTH AMERICAN F-86 SABRE

Date 1949 **Origin** US

Wingspan 11.93m (39¼ft)

Length 11.84m (38¾ft)

Top speed 1,114kph (692mph)

Engine 26.3kN (5,910lb) General Electric J73-GE-3D

The first swept-wing fighter in the US Air Force, the F-86 was also a highly successful fighter that was able to take on the MiG-15. Including all variants, over 9,000 F-86s were built – more than any other Western jet fighter.

Inflight refuelling probe



Variable exhaust nozzle

▼ BAE HARRIER II GR9A

Date 1989 **Origin** UK

Wingspan 9.25m (30½ft)

Length 14.12m (46½ft)

Top speed 1,065kph (662mph)

Engine 96.7kN (21,750lb) Rolls-Royce Pegasus Mk 105 vectored turbofan

The most advanced of all the Harriers, a series that began in 1969, the GR9A is a Vertical/Short Take-off and Landing (V/STOL) jet aircraft. This model is primarily used as a light strike aircraft.